



Game Design Document

Design decisions and implementation gates for the alpha reference.

Current as of 24 September 2026

This page updates the reference pages that follow. Where older wording differs, use this revision until the full canonical card-file migration is approved.

Core player experience

- FORGE = Fan-Originated Releases & Game Expansions. A player creates a Catalyst, tests it, discovers a surprising result, refines it, and returns to FORGE. Card -> Catalyst -> Character -> Legacy describes the long-term attachment goal.
- First-session guidance uses brief bullets and scenario popups with Continue and Go Back while the player creates five FORGE cards. Hook Model terminology stays out of player-facing menus.

Canonical FORGE sequence

- Alignment -> permitted Race -> permitted Skill -> Effect Class. Normal requires Lore; Effect requires Effect Text and optional Lore; Fusion requires Fusion rules/materials, Effect Text, and optional Lore. Then set Pressure, Counter Pressure, Rank, and Catalyst Resolution.
- Alignment-to-Race and Race-to-Skill choices must be constrained by the approved canonical tree. Existing card records and old KINDS are not automatically approved by this revision page; the full name/effect migration remains a release gate.

Battle and release rules

- 1v1: each player owns a separate 10,000 Chi pool. Team game: each team shares one 10,000 Chi pool. Main Deck cap: five Great Cards. Fusion Deck cap: five Great Fusion Catalysts. Combined cap: ten.
- Effect families are Spawn, Draw, Action, Destroy, and Void. Destroy by effect does not itself award a battle Kill; Capture follows Counter Pressure battle rules.
- End Phase offers Extract, Rescue, Destroy 1 Trick, and Pass Turn. The first three spend an eligible owned and controlled Catalyst. Pass Turn is free. Keep the phase display centered between opposing and active boards, with score plates outside the card lanes.
- A release needs the approved canonical card mapping, matching CNL/PTCG exports, a rebuilt SETS/CARDS ZIP, deck and gameplay tests, website submission tests, and a reviewed executable candidate.



CARRY THE FLAME!

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Complete rules, systems, edge cases, and scenario reference

Internal / organized-play reference

End Phase ownership revision - 1 September 2026

Official alpha documentation - use only approved current card wording and published errata.



Document purpose

This is the controlling gameplay specification for Carry The Flame! alpha play. It translates the approved rule-logic record into one playable standard, identifies the data each digital implementation must preserve, and gives judges and designers a repeatable way to resolve scenarios.

Release scope: This document governs standard 1v1 first. Team, Boss, and Free For All play are included only where the alpha format defines them. Individual approved card wording can create its stated exception; older printings do not create an unstated exception.

Rule authority and terminology

Apply rules in this order: later creator ruling, approved current card wording or errata, this GDD, then the 13+ Manual and Quick Start. If no rule exists, pause the game and obtain a ruling instead of guessing.

Use now	Legacy label	Meaning
Spawn	Summon / place when classified	Move a Catalyst to a legal field position by a defined procedure.
Pressure	ATK	Battle strength used by an attacking Catalyst.
Counter Pressure	DEF	Battle strength used by a defending Catalyst.
Void	Graveyard / discard	Default destination for destroyed, discarded, and Tributed cards.
Substitute Deck	Side Deck	Between-game change pool in a Best-of-3 match.

Game model

Each player begins at 10,000 Chi, draws five cards, and has no standard mulligan. A player uses a 40-60 card Main Deck, may use a 0-15 card Fusion Deck, and may register a 0-15 card Substitute Deck for Best-of-3. A player cannot draw from an empty deck; skip that draw unless an effect says otherwise.

Zone / state	Function	Default rule
Hand	Private cards available to their owner.	A card in hand is not field-controlled.
Main Deck	Face-down draw source.	Shuffle before the match; count is public on request.
Fusion Deck	Fusion Catalyst source.	Only a legal Fusion procedure or stated exception may use it.
Catalyst Zones	Five positions for each player's Catalysts.	A direct attack requires all five opposing zones empty at declaration and resolution.
Trick / Field areas	Approved Palm, Concealed, Equip, Continuous, and Field cards.	One Field Trick per player; playing another replaces only that player's previous Field Trick.
Box	Captured non-Great Catalysts.	An Extraction can move an eligible captured Catalyst from Box to RFG.
Void	Public discard / destroyed / Tribute destination.	Use unless an approved effect gives a different destination.
RFG	Removed From Game state.	Cards remain RFG until the next game unless the resolving effect says how and when they return.

Deck construction and Great-card limits

Deck construction validates each deck type separately. A Great card is a card whose approved name contains the exact standalone word Great. Greatness and similar words do not qualify. A deck builder must use approved card names, not an older database tag, to identify Great cards.

Deck	Size	Great-card maximum	Notes
Main Deck	40-60	5 Great cards	No more than five eligible names/cards whose approved name contains Great.
Fusion Deck	0-15	5 Great Fusion Catalysts	No more than five Great Fusion Catalyst cards; this is a separate cap.
Total across both	40-75	10 Great cards maximum	At most five in Main plus at most five Great Fusion Catalysts in Fusion.
Substitute Deck	0-15	Must preserve legal post-substitute decks	After substitution, Main and Fusion Deck must still meet their own Great caps and size limits.

Validation invariant: A legal standard configuration never contains more than 5 Great cards in the Main Deck, more than 5 Great Fusion Catalysts in the Fusion Deck, or more than 10 Great cards across those two deck types.

Match setup and victory

1. Register decks, verify Main, Fusion, Substitute, and Great limits, then determine first player by the event method.
2. Each player shuffles, presents the Main Deck, draws five, starts at 10,000 Chi, and begins with no Catalyst unless a stated setup effect applies.
3. The first player takes a Draw Phase but cannot declare a Battle Phase attack on their first turn.
4. Win immediately when a condition is met: reduce opponent Chi to 0 or less, reach seven Kills, or reach seven Extractions. If more than one win condition is created together, apply Chi KO first, then seven Kills, then seven Extractions.

Turn state machine

Phase	Required system action	Key limits / timing
1. Turn Start	Start-turn effects in defined order.	Resolve mandatory start-turn actions before Draw.
2. Draw	Draw one card.	An empty deck skips the draw, not the game.
3. Ignition	Use legal ignition effects.	Only cards whose current approved wording permits this timing.
4. Action	Spawn, Set, activate effects, and build Chains.	Normal Spawn and Set share a player-specific normal allowance.
5. Battle	Declare legal attacks and resolve battles.	First player cannot attack on turn one.
6. Resolution	Resolve pending effects, triggers, and clean-up.	Newest Chain link resolves first.
7. End	Choose one End action or Pass Turn.	A paid action uses one Catalyst you own and control; Spawn age does not matter.

Spawns: normal, Special, Fusion, and Libra

A Normal Spawn and a Set consume the same normal allowance. Ranks 1-4 need no Tribute, Ranks 5-6 need one Tribute, and Ranks 7+ need two Tributes. A Tribute normally goes to the Void. An effect may grant an additional Normal Spawn only if it says so.

A Special Spawn is only a procedure explicitly classified as Special by approved wording or errata. Do not infer that a return, placement, token creation, or replacement is Special just because it resembles one.

Shotgun Rule: After every successful Special Spawn, the opponent immediately draws one card. This happens after the Spawn succeeds and before on-Spawn effects or response windows. Fusion and Libra both trigger Shotgun. A failed or negated Spawn does not count and does not cause the draw.

Completed procedure	Special-Spawn count	Shotgun
Single approved Special Spawn	1	Opponent draws 1 immediately.
Fusion procedure	1	Opponent draws 1 after the Fusion Catalyst is successfully Spawned.
Libra procedure with multiple placements	1	Opponent draws 1 after the complete Libra procedure succeeds.
Failed / negated Spawn	0	No draw.

Five-Special-Spawn cap: A player/team can complete no more than five Special Spawns per turn. A procedure that would become the sixth cannot begin or resolve as a Special Spawn: pay no cost, place no Catalyst, and do not trigger Shotgun. Continue only independent instructions that remain legal.

Tricks, Chains, and priority

Palm Tricks are played from the hand when their timing allows. Concealed Tricks are set and used through their approved conditions. Continuous, Equip, Quick, Counter, and Field are subtypes, not replacement card classes. Continuous buffs stack unless an effect says otherwise: two active Volcano effects each grant their stated bonus.

When a player activates an effect, opponents receive a legal response opportunity. Each new Chain link sits above the previous one; resolve from newest to oldest. Once a Counter Trick is on a Chain, only another Counter Trick may be added above it. Resolve as much as possible. If a card cannot legally be activated because a required instruction cannot be carried out, it cannot be played.

Battle procedure

1. Choose an attacking Catalyst and a legal target, or declare a direct attack only if all five opposing Catalyst Zones are empty at declaration and resolution.
2. Apply legal attack declarations, responses, continuous modifiers, and effects. Use current Pressure and Counter Pressure values.
3. Resolve the battle result. Destruction, Capture, Kill, Chi damage, and any stated trigger occur in their defined result order.

Battle	Result
Pressure vs. Pressure	Higher Pressure destroys the lower Catalyst to Void and deals Chi damage equal to the difference. Equal Pressure destroys both and gives one Kill to each player.



Battle	Result
Pressure vs. Counter Pressure	If the attacking Pressure is not enough, apply the approved Counter Pressure result. When a non-Great Catalyst is defeated by Counter Pressure, Capture it to the attacker's Box.
Great Catalyst defeated by Counter Pressure	It goes to Void, gives the opponent one Kill, and deals no battle Logic/Chi damage from that result.
Direct attack	Deal the attacking Catalyst's legal direct battle damage to Chi; legality must still be true when resolution begins.

End rights, extraction, and rescue

At End Phase choose at most one: Extract, Rescue, Destroy 1 Trick, or Pass Turn. A paid action sends one Catalyst you own and control from a Catalyst Zone to the Void. A newly Spawned Catalyst you own and control may pay. A Catalyst owned by an opponent cannot pay, even if you temporarily or permanently control it. Taking control never transfers ownership.

End choice	Purpose
Extract	Move a captured, eligible non-Great Catalyst from the opponent's Box to RFG and gain one Extraction.
Rescue	Use the approved Rescue procedure; observe all stated ownership, zone, and cost restrictions.
Destroy 1 Trick	Use the approved right to destroy one eligible Trick under the specified conditions.
Pass Turn	Take no End action; no End action cost is paid.

Multiplayer formats

In 2v2, hands and Normal Spawns are individual. Completed Special Spawns, card-name limits, and per-card usage are team-shared unless a format rule says otherwise. Teammates may use shared team-controlled field cards where their approved wording allows. Team Chi, team field, Kills, Extractions, and the five-Special-Spawn cap are shared.

Boss and Free For All require the current format sheet. Free For All has no implied default targeting, priority, tie, or reveal procedure; the organizer publishes those details before the match.

Scenario and ruling appendix

S1 - Third Fusion

A player completed two approved Special Spawns, then Fuses. The Fusion is the third completed Special Spawn. It succeeds, then the opponent immediately draws one before the Fusion's on-Spawn text.

S2 - Negated Fusion

A Fusion procedure is negated before completion. It does not use a Special-Spawn count and no Shotgun draw occurs.

S3 - Fifth then sixth

After completing the fifth Special Spawn, a later effect instructs a Special Spawn. That sixth procedure cannot begin or resolve; no cost is paid and no Shotgun occurs.

S4 - Libra

Libra places several legal Catalysts in one approved procedure. The group is one Special Spawn, so it uses one count and creates one Shotgun draw after it completes.

S5 - Direct attack closes

Five opposing zones are empty at declaration. Before resolution, an effect Spawns a Catalyst to an opposing zone. The direct attack is no longer legal at resolution and does not deal direct damage.

S6 - Great Counter Pressure

A Great Catalyst loses to Counter Pressure. Put it in Void, award one Kill to the opposing player, and do not apply battle Logic/Chi damage from that loss.

S7 - Two Volcanoes

Two active continuous Volcano effects each say FIRE Catalysts gain +400 Pressure. A legal FIRE Catalyst gains +800 total unless an effect makes the bonuses non-stacking.

S8 - Field replacement

Each player may control one Field Trick. If Player A plays a second Field Trick, Player A's old Field Trick is destroyed; Player B's Field Trick remains.

S9 - Great validation

A Main Deck contains five approved names with the standalone word Great and one card named Greatness Rising. Greatness Rising is not Great for the cap. A sixth actual Great card makes the Main Deck illegal.

S10 - Substitute check

After a Best-of-3 substitution, the new Main Deck contains six Great cards. The substitution is illegal; the player must restore a legal configuration.

S11 - Empty deck

A player has no cards in Main Deck during Draw. They skip the draw and remain in the game unless another win/loss rule applies.

S12 - Legacy timing

A legacy card refers to an old phase that has no approved errata. It is not legal for current alpha play until its individual timing is rewritten.

S13 - Newly Spawned payment

You Spawn a Catalyst that you own, then reach your End Phase. You may send that newly Spawned Catalyst to the Void to pay for Extract, Rescue, or Destroy 1 Trick because you both own and control it.

S14 - Borrowed Catalyst payment

You take control of an opponent-owned Catalyst until the End Phase. You may not send it to the Void to pay for an End action. It stays in play and returns as the control effect says because control did not change its owner.

Card-specific approved rulings

The following rulings are included as a design implementation reference. They do not replace exact approved card text; cards awaiting rewrite remain unavailable in sanctioned alpha play.

Card / subject	Approved implementation note
Zero Degrees	Controller begins in Action before the other player acts; the next two completed player turns are locked as approved.
Serpent	From hand, remove two EARTH and two WIND cards to Void as the approved requirement; its five-coin battle use is once per battle.
Ultimate Price	The affected subject cannot attack or use effects for three completed turns; then the named price goes to Void.
Nolan	Special Spawn from hand using the required rank 8+ offerings; cannot attack on the Spawn turn; later direct Chi effect follows approved wording.
Reaper	May use any Equip card for its named requirement, while preserving every other stated restriction.
Rapier	Resolve normal battle first; then apply positive Pressure-minus-Counter-Pressure piercing Chi damage where approved.
Great One	May be linked to an eligible rank 4 or lower source as stated; remove it from game when that source is destroyed.
Blazing Inferno Volcano	Either player may control a face-up copy; it destroys itself if none remains and grants FIRE +1000 as approved.
Inferno Dragon	The named support applies to either player's eligible Inferno Dragon where the card says it does.
Inferno Takeover	Its controller makes the choice specified by the card at the time specified by the card.
Toolbox	During Ignition, pay 1000 Chi, shuffle an Equip Palm Trick from hand into the Main Deck, then draw one card.
Curse Flame Ghost	Change Attribute to FIRE, keep existing KINDS, and add Vampire; the change reverses when the approved effect ends.
Phoenix Soul	Mode 2 snapshots the number of FIRE cards only at resolution; it does not re-count later.
Newz	All face-up Warriors on both sides receive +200 Pressure.
Destin Newz	Requires itself plus a distinct rank 5 Warrior; the approved hand Special Spawn prize cannot attack that turn.
Ace	Copies only the approved ability through End Phase; it does not copy the target's name, stats, or other properties.
Fusion Zone	Once per team per turn.

Digital and judge acceptance checks

- Deck validator checks Main size, Fusion size, Substitute size, 5 Main Great cap, 5 Fusion Great Fusion Catalyst cap, and total 10 Great cap.
- Every Spawn outcome records attempted, failed/negated, or completed. Only completed Special Spawns increment the counter and create Shotgun.
- Shotgun is queued before on-Spawn triggers and before the normal response window.
- Direct attack rechecks empty opposing Catalyst Zones at resolution.
- Each player has a separate Field Trick slot; each team has a shared Special Spawn counter in 2v2.
- Paid End actions validate that the acting player is both Owner and Controller of the payment Catalyst. The engine does not check how recently that Catalyst was Spawned.
- A card with unapproved legacy timing displays Requires Approved Errata and is excluded from legal play.